Rainswept Dream Game Design Document

GAME301 – Project 1 - Riku Yuki Darroch – 300606468

Introduction

Rainswept Dream is an abstract, retro inspired horror puzzle game concept set in a looping dream. The player will explore and complete puzzles while facing embodiments of the character's insecurities before finding the key to his childhood bedroom and accepting his childhood self as a part of himself and waking up in the real world. The game has a purposefully low poly aesthetic inspired by games from the 6th console generation, with bleak, abstract and sometimes absurdist visuals that play to the narrative.

The main inspirations of this game are Silent Hill 2, Shenmue, Earthbound, Omori, and Disco Elysium.

Overview

The premise is that the main character comes back to his hometown after his parents die and he inherits his childhood home. However, once he arrives there is an unnerving and lonely atmosphere as if the town itself is telling him he should not be here. This is insinuated through the way that the NPCs speak to the main character, the lack of music, and the visual style.

The player begins intentionally not given direction, rather aimlessly exploring the town, encountering the inhabitants, the different areas, and the materialized concepts of emotions and insecurities tied to physical places and people. While exploring and interacting with things from the character's past, a journal is filled that gives explanation and exposition of the world and his emotional past, along with hints to puzzles that unlock the ending of the game and a map of the area allowing for backtracking and keeping track of information.

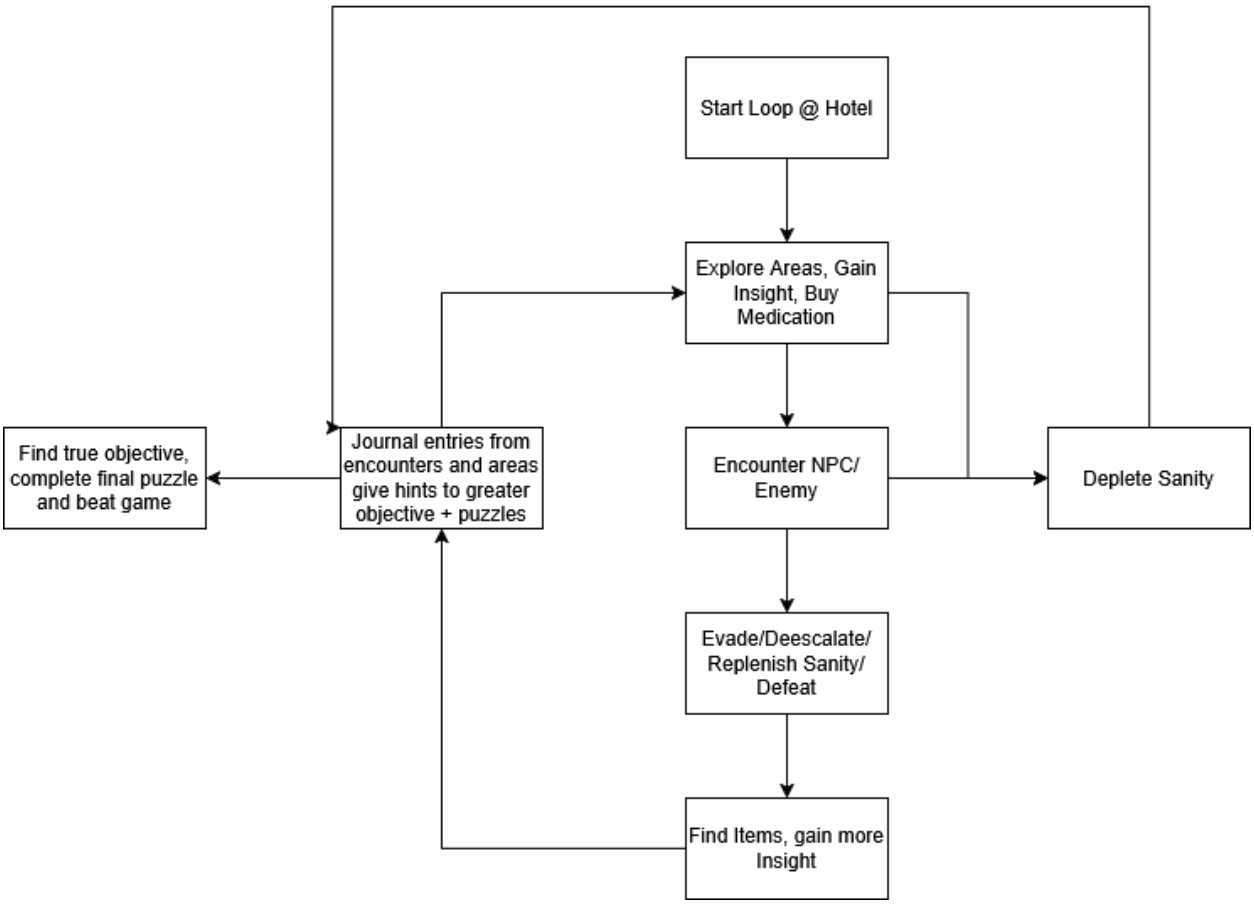
Within the town there are a range of NPCs that talk to the player character with the same shallow inflection as if they were in an open world game but the story had progressed beyond the area, some of which are completely normal while some range from abstract

emotional concepts or absurdist unrealistic characters that are intentionally unquestioned to add to the dreamlike element to it. Every NPC will be interactive, with a couple lines of dialogue, however if the NPC says something to the player character that brings up emotional scars, it will deplete sanity.

Sanity is the health system of the game, if depleted to zero then the game will be over, and the player will be sent back to the beginning of the game, every item will be reset, however the journal will be carried over from previous runs. Sanity can be drained in multiple ways, either abruptly by having an NPC bring up an emotional scar that the player character is still processing, or getting attacked by a monster, or passively by spending too much time in the thick fog surrounding areas that have emotional scars tied to them. Sanity can be replenished multiple ways, either by pills where one box can be bought from the pharmacy per run with 5 pills in it, or passively from cigarettes that can be bought from the gas station. Both can be bought from the drug dealer who spends their time at certain parts of the map as well. As there is no currency in this game, they can be bought from each vendor once per run, along with scavenging from rubbish bins and gutters around the map.

Eventually, after exploring the town and interacting with enough NPCs, the journal will fill out along with hints to the fragmented greater puzzle and their locations. Every time the journal is filled, the player gains insight, which in small amounts increases the threshold of sanity. Solving the greater puzzle will require the player to face their demons, i.e. hostile NPCs, gather items and collect them together to an altar, and throwing them in before having the forest return the key to his childhood room to him. After which they can return to the room and apologize for locking the childhood version of himself into his room and accepting him as a part of himself. Waking up as a new more insightful man.

Gameplay



The player starts the loop at a hotel in the middle of the town. Intentionally the objective of the game is left vague, the player has no choice but to aimlessly explore the town. The player's movement is intentionally stiff and tanky, combined with fixed camera angles that follow the player at low angles to withhold information and surprise the player with enemies.

While wandering around in the world, the player is rewarded for exploring. Giving them an objective without direction while holding the players' hand as little as possible. Every time the player discovers a new area of interest, talks to a new character, acquires a new item, or encounters a new enemy, along with insight (which indicates an increased sanity meter max) they unlock a new journal entry that hints towards the greater goal of the game. The idea is that by discovering and picking up items they see the individual pieces of the puzzle, and through the journal entries and the conversations with NPCs they put those pieces together.

There are 4 monsters that roam different parts of the map that the player must avoid. They are impossible to kill, however they can be staggered to avoid getting attacked when in close quarters by hitting them with an item the player discovers. Each monster represents an almost insurmountable emotional barrier that the player character burdens themselves with.

As mentioned previously, the aim of the game is to bring all of the key items individually, that have emotional ties to them to an alter located in a conspicuous place on the map, to force the player into uncomfortable experiences as a means to convey the narrative and get the key given back to you by the forest.

There is an inventory system in this game, where the main character will be able to store an uncapped amount of cigarettes and medication on him at all times, along with a weapon, however will only be able to carry one of the items for the greater puzzle at a given time, as they carry heavy emotional burden.

While discovering the player can scavenge loose medication bottles or cigarettes with 1 or 2 of each consumable within certain interactable things such as public rubbish bins, gutters, in leaves, or public bathrooms. Or they can also be bought one time per vendor per loop. In the event that the player's sanity depletes, the world is reset, their inventory is cleared, and the player respawns at the beginning of the game, however the journal entries and the insight is carried over. Allowing the player to redo the game with their new knowledge.

Map

The different areas in the town that the player can explore are; the Town Centre, The School, The Street, The Boat Harbor, The Play Ground, The Beach, The Houses, the Nature Reserve and Yacht Club. Along with some intererior buildings such as the Hotel Room, The childhood home and the forest.

Story

The background of the story is that the player character threw away the key to your childhood bedroom into the woods before the events of this game. The player character did this because he wanted to leave all his painful experiences in life behind him and start a new life somewhere else. Letting the emotions and sadness fester in a place he doesn't see and creating a time capsule to his childhood in his own mind.

The story of this game is about how trauma makes you deny yourself, your own experiences and lock them away so that you can pretend to live as if they aren't a part of your life. However, as you live and experience the trials of life you tend to be disappointed by the way you are emotionally handling them, comparing yourself to others who grew up differently. By confronting these traumas and casting symbols of each of them into the altar, you are

proving to the woods that you are ready to accept what is behind the door of your childhood room, which is your childhood self, accepting them as yourself, and moving forward compassionate to yourself.

Rainswept Dream is a horror game that takes place inside a looping dream. I want to play on the unintentional but inherent liminal loneliness that comes from the limitations that games from the early 2000s where to save memory, NPCs will say minimal lines of dialogue. The feeling of NPCs running out of things to say to the player character is a very isolating experience, especially when the player wants to talk to these characters.

The fact the player character is stuck in a loop where everyone forgets the events of the previous loops except for him and the progress from the previous loops carry over is a narrative choice that adds to the isolating atmosphere of the game. The ambiguity of whether the town is in a loop plays to the aesthetic of the town and the isolating emotional turmoil the player character is experiencing.

The fact that the game is set in a dream is important not only because it gives a reason for the player character to confront emotions that they bottle away, but also because it gives a reason for the emotions to also confront the player character as well. To accentuate the dreamlike nature of this world, I want to include absurdist elements that are not questioned to be real or fake at any point, along with incorporating occurrences in dreams into the gameplay and puzzles such as sleep paralysis and unrealistic symbols of emotions.

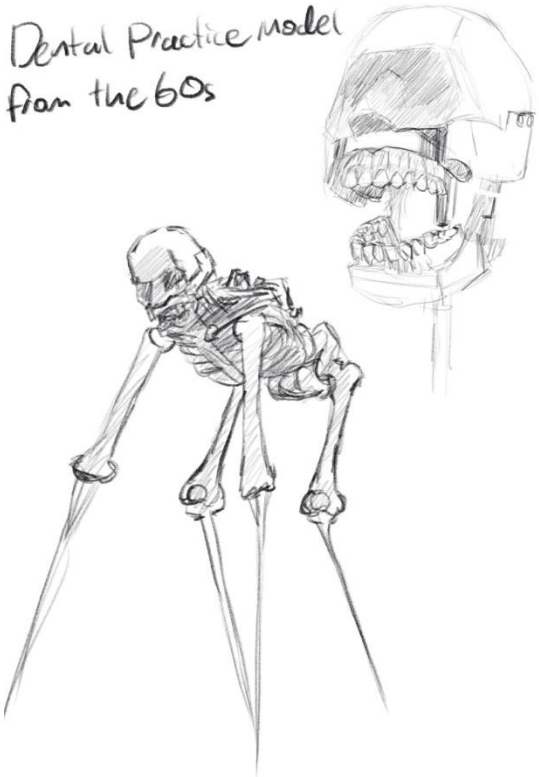
The story is told mostly through journal entries scrawled into paper whenever the player interacts with a place or person or monster of interest. Each journal entry has information about the players' emotional experiences tied to a certain person or place, along with information that leads to the final puzzle of the game being solved. However, the story of the game is also supported by the dialogue from NPCs and embodiments of emotional scars that the player can interact with during the duration of the game.

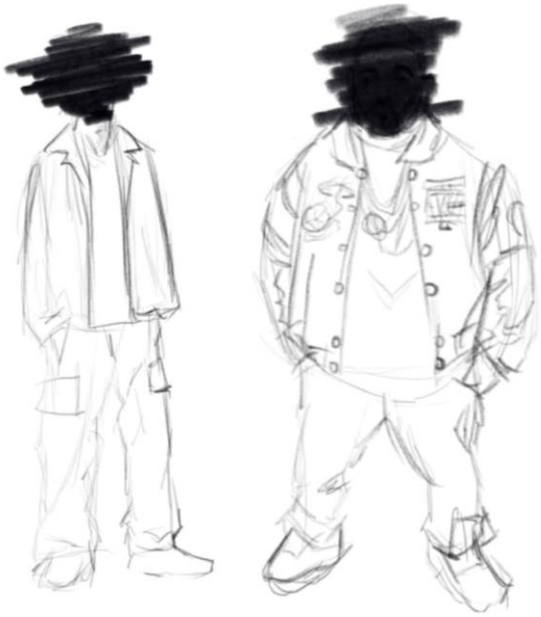
Art

The visual style of the game will follow closely the retro low-poly and simple lit visual style of games from the Dreamcast, PlayStation 2 and PC games from the early to mid-2000s. This is playing to the limitations of time for this project, however also an aesthetic choice as it plays perfectly into the lonely aspects of video games that limitations from that era caused. As per the genre of game this is, nailing the atmosphere is very important, meaning the color scheme and lighting combined with the sound needs to sell the aesthetic as that aspect is what intrigues a player to keep exploring. Character and monster designs will be drawn by me; some examples are pictured below.

Yo Bro, You lookin for some caps?
You be Wilin' dog, but I Fuck with you

Dental Practice model from the 60s





Trees W/ Faces

Ainu protection God

Sound

The soundscape of the game will be mostly diegetic, such as the sounds of waves hitting the shoreline, breeze blowing through the trees of a forest, the hum of convenience store fridges. However, encounters with the apparitions, humanoid monsters, or the altar will be accompanied by a score of wispy sustained chords, incomplete progressions and simple melodies that accompany the visuals. The lack of music itself is an aesthetic choice that plays into the loneliness created by the medium.

Final Notes

I recognize that abstract games are a hard sell and can be confusing to the average audience, and that this game concept is tailored specifically to my own experiences with dreams, self-reflection and personal growth. I want this game prototype itself to be a tale of learning to live with yourself as a young adult and not letting your negative experiences and emotional baggage weigh you down when life is rough. While it is not necessarily a single genre, and a blend of elements of some very different games, I think it can be an intriguing video game idea.